# IG FACE-OFF

## Q. How critical is this election for Sri Lanka?

**RANIL WICKREMESINGHE:** It will decide the future of Sri Lanka. Whether the economic reforms will go on. Whether people will be better-off or if the whole thing comes apart and we go back to a situation like July 2022, or maybe worse. But we won't get any help this time. So, this is a make or break election for Sri Lanka. Either we go ahead with the reforms we have done, the agreements we have made and adhere to the benchmarks and go ahead, otherwise this whole thing will come apart and it could be worse than 2022.

**SAJITH PREMADASA:** Presently, Sri Lanka is governed by an administration that does not have a people's mandate. It's the very same majority in parliament that had proposed illogical and misunderstood economic policies that saw Sri Lanka fall into the situation of economic bankruptcy. The very same people who put Sri Lanka into this terrible situation that devastated many lives. They themselves formed into a coalition to have a replacement. What we have is a replacement president elected by a group of parliamentarians who have lost their mandate. So it's very important that people's voices are heard, that people themselves have an opportunity to elect their own leader and not go through the same old facade of a selected leader. We need an elected leader. The first important thing is the necessity for the people's mandate. Second, even though it's not in that kind of a pecking order, similar importance has to be attached to bring Sri Lanka out of this situation of economic catastrophe. Right now, we have what you may call an economic Armageddon. A financial bankruptcy that has detrimentally impacted the lives of all 22 million citizens. In order to extricate Sri Lanka out of this mess, we need a precise, people-led, people-supported programme that is based on rationality and on a proper comprehension of the political economy. And we need to have evidence-based decision-making processes deciding on policy. Sri Lanka has gone through a lot through extreme right wing, neo-liberal economic policies that have basically made the rich richer and the poor poorer. We don't subscribe to that. It has also resulted in crony capitalism. On the other hand, we fully believe that the extreme left wing socialistic way will also not provide results for the benefit of the country and the people. So, a middle of the road vision is what we will provide.



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**"WE HAVE AN ECONOMIC ARMAGEDDON"**
**– SAJITH PREMADASA**

**"WE MUST GO AHEAD WITH OUR REFORMS AND ADHERE TO BENCHMARKS, OTHERWISE THE WHOLE THING WILL COME APART AND IT CAN BE WORSE THAN 2022"**

**"FINANCIAL BANKRUPTCY HIT ALL 22 MN CITIZENS. SRI LANKA NEEDS A PEOPLE-LED RATIONAL GOVERNMENT, NOT RULERS THAT LIVE IN CLOUD CUCKOO LAND"**